A Steady Rain

By Keith Huff

Each character speaks only to the audience unless otherwise noted.

DENNY: (Pg 55-56) *(To Joey)* Think you'd know the eyes of a demon if you saw one? *(beat)*

JOEY: *(To Denny)* We didn't know, Denny. First thing we've got to do to face this thing is let ourselves off the hook. We didn't know.

DENNY: *(To Joey)* But we should know, Joey. We should know the eyes of a demon when we see one. It's our job. Otherwise we end up with demons for friends. *(beat)*

JOEY: (Pg 60) We sat there in that rain for, I don't know, an hour, longer, not a word, just Denny mumbling under his breath.

DENNY: *(To Joey)* They want heroes, Joey. Superhuman, that's what they want us to be. Abel to tell good from evil in a blink. That's what they want.

JOEY: (Pg 34) [Denny] was my best friend. My partner. Always back to back, me and Den.

DENNY: (Pg 10) I known the guy since kinnygarten.

JOEY: (Pg 64) *(remembering)* Denny'd make up these games. To pass the time. For nothing, for fun. Denny invented rock tag. He called it Last Man Standing. Plenty of rocks handy for ammo. The object of the game, of course, was to be the last man standing.

DENNY: (Pg 46) Nobody knows this, I virtually brought the guy back from the dead he drank so bad. You know how many times I covered for that guy, signed in for him, covered his beat? He's like my brother, I love the guy, but [he] can be the biggest pain in the ass sometimes.

JOEY: (Pg 12) Denny, to keep me off the sauce, [had] me over just about every night of the week. I appreciated the gesture. It was a good thing to do. Denny was always doing things like that, always looking out for people. He was a good guy. **(Pg 21)** It started to rain that night, I remember. I don't think it let up more than a minute or two till this whole mess was over. **(Pg 45)** – I blamed it on the rain

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INTRODUCTION

Law enforcement is dangerous work. But these days, the gravest threat to police officers' lives comes not from criminals but from themselves – death by suicide. In a world where toughness is prized, they hesitate to reveal frailties for fear of jeopardizing their careers. Such reluctance becomes especially dangerous with officers who have temporarily lost their shields or been put on modified duty pending investigations that could cost them their careers. Fear of losing reputation and friends is more than enough to drive them over the edge. Denny and Joey, partners and best friends since childhood, are two cops on the edge.

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JOEY: **(Pg 37)** [It] was one of those days you dread. Tail end of our shift, around one a.m., a call came in, routine disorderly in an alley behind an apartment complex near Broadway and Sheridan, the part of town Denny called Deviant Corners. I responded, said we'd check it out. Without a word, Denny turned around the squad car and floored it.

DENNY: We pull up this alley off Deviant Corners. Right away in the headlights is this kid, this Vietnamese kid, stoned out of his mind. Not a stitch of clothes. He's fumbling through the garbage cans, trying to stack 'em up and make like this stairway to heaven over a tall, wood fence. We keep the headlights on the kid. We draw our service revolvers 'cause any cop, you see somebody out of control this way, it's usually PCP . . .

JOEY: So you play it safe.

DENNY: We go to him slow, cautious.

JOEY: He turns, sees us.

DENNY: We can see the kid's in tears, verge of hysteria just about. And [he] comes running at us like that 'Nam photo. Yunno, that girl running naked from the napalm blitzkrieg.

JOEY: Tears running down his face, yammering a mile a minute in Vietnamese about something. He slobbers up to us, ignoring any order we toss him.

DENNY: [He] ducks under my gun arm and locks his arms around me. Hugging me. 'Course I don't shoot. I mean I can see he's unarmed. I look over to Joey for a little assistance. So Joey tells me . . .

JOEY: *(To Denny)* Try to calm the kid down while I go to the car for a blanket.

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DENNY: What do you do to calm this kid down, sing him a Vietnamese lullaby? He's like thirteen or fourteen and he's naked. I mean, I can't hug him back. So I'm standing there like a jerk, both arms in the air, all these people watching from the windowsill bleachers overhead, till Joey finally comes back with the blanket and wraps the kid in it. Joey practically had to peel the kid off of me.

JOEY: We pried him loose eventually. Trying to talk him down and getting nowhere. This beefy blond guy, he looked like a surfer, he comes up to us from outta one of the basement apartments off of the alley carrying a yellow umbrella and says he'll take care of Li-Yao.

DENNY: He tells us the kid's name is Li-Yao. He's from Vietnam, sure enough, and he's his nephew or cousin or both. I forgot what he said exactly. But I do remember he said the kid had some kinda war trauma and flips out.

JOEY: Which made sense at the time. So Denny tells me . . .

DENNY: *(To Joey)* Release him to his uncle's custody and let's amscray, uh? Joey didn't wanna do it at first.

JOEY: Li-Yao seemed scared to death of his uncle. I told him I thought maybe we should bring the kid and his uncle in, maybe hunt down an interpreter, hceck out what the kid's saying. Deny told me . . .

DENNY: *(To Joey)* Fine, J. Play Mother Teresa. Save the world. I got other official police business to conduct.

JOEY: . . . and took off for the squad car. The kid, Li-Yao, he went limp in my arms. I had to actually catch him, hold him up. The guy, the one who said he was the uncle, he told me this is what happens when Li-Yao's posttraumatic stress disorder medication finally kicks in. So, I'm standing there with this passed-out naked kid in my arms [and] I don't know what to do. So I handed Li-Yao over to his uncle. The guy seemed nice enough. I looked him square in the eye to get a read. He seemed decent. He really did.

DENNY: **(Pg 44)** So this Puerto Rican stiff was at the Citgo, I walked up to him very polite, I asked him: "Excuse me, sir, I'd like to ask you a few questions about your whereabouts last evening." And like that, he drops his groceries, lunges for his car, and drives off. My

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partner, he's off dealing with this alleyway incident across the street. So, no time to call him, I go after this Puerto Rican gentleman. I mean, hey, running from a cop is usually a pretty persuasive indicator something ugly's amuck. Pouring rain, he tries to jump the concrete embankment doing 80, flips his car over two or three times and lands it upside down. Sure, I woulda called in for backup, woulda followed protocol, but Joey, he's out on another call and I didn't wanna cause any more accidents or anything. They guy died in the wreck. It was the guy's own fault. I blamed it on the rain. *(gesturing to himself)* Sole survivor of the altercation: Last Man Standing.

JOEY: **(Pg 47)** Waiting. That's what that summer was about. An excruciating exercise in patience. Waiting for things to blow sky-high between Denny and me. Waiting for an end to the rain. A lighter air. A brighter sky. Then they caught the psycho guy, this cannibal worse than anything anybody'd ever seen in the movies, and it turned out the Vietnamese boy Li-Yao was one of his victims.

DENNY: No sooner [does] the news flash the guy's pictures than the boards are lit up with a million or more calls, witnesses the night these two dipshit beat cops turned this crying Vietnamese kid over to the cannibal killer. I mean parts of this kid's body have still not been found.

JOEY: Instead of piecing together a case, they spent most of the early part of their investigation tying Denny and me to Li-Yao. Going to that length to ID a couple of scapegoats sure made it seem like they were out to nail us. First, [the chief] suspended us both with pay. Week later, after the press got ahold of it, we were suspended without pay. If we admitted breaching protocol by not running Li-Yao in, he promised us reinstatement in a month. Denny didn't want to admit any wrongdoing.

DENNY: At how many paces can you identify a serial killer who eats his victims' hearts. I mean, how the hell were we supposed to know? We believed he was his uncle. I don't know Asian! [I have] kids of my own, don't you think this eats me up? I still see his face, all the time his face, and I walk around, awake, asleep, I still feel his arms around me like I was his last saving grace and I failed him. Ain't that punishment enough?

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JOEY: Denny took it hard. He collapsed inside. His drinking got worse. I called him on the track marks up and down his arm, he told me mosquito bites.

DENNY: All I'm trying to do, like any other man, is take care of my family. Why take away my means to do that? Why?

JOEY: Denny went off the deep end that night. Me and a couple of other cops found him parked out on the flooded ninth hole of the Waveland Golf Course. He said he only had two or three beers, but it takes more than that to tank Denny. I found a couple of spent vials of morphine and a syringe. We carried him into his house, into the light **(Pg 55)** He wouldn't look at me.

DENNY: *(To Joey)* Think you'd know the eyes of a demon if you saw one?

JOEY: *(To Denny)* We didn't know Denny. First thing we've got to do to face this thing is let ourselves off the hook. We didn't know

DENNY: *(To Joey)* But we should know, Joey. We should know the eyes of a demon when we see one **(Pg 61)** . . . Get out! . . . Get out! *(completely broken)* I can't protect 'em from it anymore, Joey.

JOEY: *(To Denny)* I know, Denny, I know. You can't take responsibility for it all, Denny.

DENNY: *(To Joey)* Family man, you gotta. I brought it home with me. I can't wash it off. It's infected everything. It's in me, Joey. It **is** me *(Pause)* Take care of 'em for me, Joey.

JOEY: *(To Denny)* We take care of each other, Den. Back-to-back. Haven't we always? *(Denny shoves Joey away roughly)*

DENNY: *(To Joey)* Back-to-back, J. Starsky and Hutch. Like the old days.

JOEY: I looked at Denny. He was loading [a] service revolver. Two steps and I heard the shot. *(long beat)* The Department didn't honor Denny's pension. There was no life insurance, either, because it was a suicide. When I took Connie [his wife] to make arrangements for Denny's funeral, we decided to have him cremated. I don't think he would have liked the idea of lying to rot in some cold plot of dirt for all eternity. Cremation at least saved us the cost of having his face reconstructed. He popped the gun just under his chin. *(long beat)* Denny was a part of me, gone forever. **(Pg 34)** My best friend. My partner. Always back to

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back, me and Den. **(Pg 64)** Denny invented rock tag. He called it Last Man Standing . . . and the rain . . . **(Pg 61)** The rain finally let up.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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